Symbolic codes

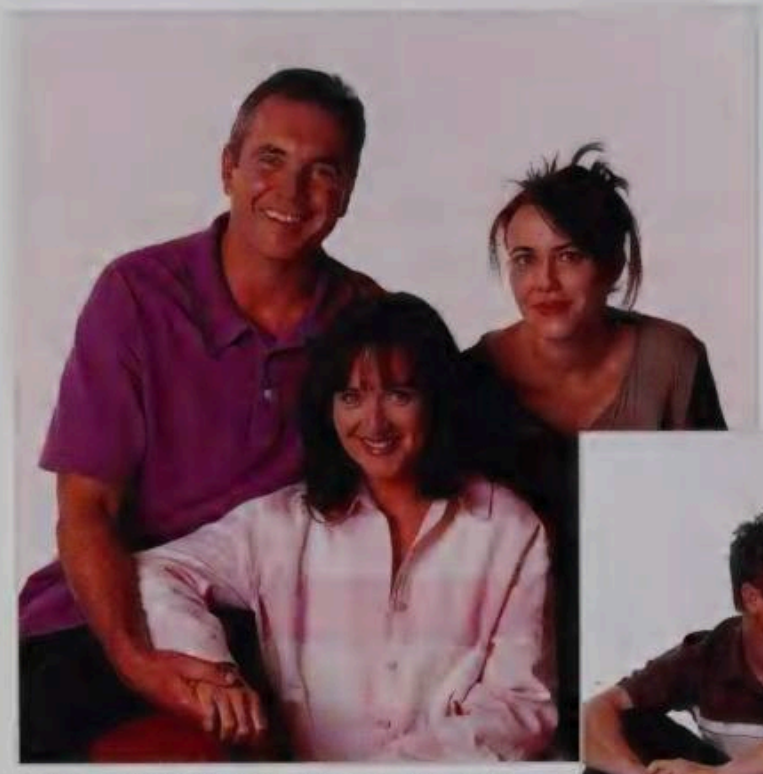
Objects, settings, body language, clothing, colour and soundtrack – the **mise-en-scene** of the sequence – use **symbolic codes** to inform the viewer. As you examine the text, you read the meaning of what you see and hear. People's cultural backgrounds will be important in the way they read an image. Facial expressions and body language are read according to the ways people's backgrounds have led them to interpret them. A polite hand gesture in some cultures may give offence in others. It all depends on a person's **situated culture**.

KEY TERMS

Mise-en-scene settings, costumes, body language, etc. used within the scene to convey the message to the audience

Situated culture the everyday surroundings and modes of behaviour shared with others from a similar cultural background

Symbolic codes how cultural symbols inform the audience about the text





7 What can you tell about the characters of *Neighbours* from these images?

ACTIVITY 3

Watch the title sequence of *Neighbours*.

1 Answer these questions using only what you can see.
   - Where do the characters live?
   - What is each of the characters telling us from their expressions and gestures?

2 Imagine you have been asked to introduce a new character into the programme, such as an elderly aunt who nags everyone. In groups, try different poses and facial expressions to suggest the sort of character you want. Act these out for the rest of the group as a 'freeze-frames' or tableaus where you adopt the pose and stay perfectly still to show what the still picture will look like. Discuss which was the most effective and appropriate for the programme.

If you watch the title sequence you will also hear the **signature tune.** This soon becomes recognisable to the audience and is seen as belonging to it like its 'signature'. Signature tunes signal themes in different ways.

- Some signature tunes communicate meaning through the style, mood and tone.
- Sometimes a particular instrument will be used to signal the setting. In *Coronation Street* the trumpet suggests brass band music associated with working-class northern England – the setting for the programme.
- Some signature tunes have song lyrics which prepare the audience for the programme by introducing themes that will be explored.

ACTIVITY 4

1 Think about the signature tune for *Neighbours*. What do the lyrics tell you about the story?

2 Choose one other signature tune with lyrics. How do the music and the words signal the themes of the programme?

Written codes

The writing on the screen may seem less important than the pictures and the music, but the font style and size, together with the position and movement of the text, can contribute to the ways the audience read the meaning. Look at the style of font used for the hit show *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* in **8**.



This lettering helps to convey meaning

Suggest two reasons why the title has been designed in this way. How does it signal the **genre** of the programme? Why has this particular font been chosen?

Does the font style make a difference to the way the text is read?

KEY TERMS

Genre a type or category of media text, such as a documentary, with certain predictable characteristics

Signature tune the soundtrack played over the images in the title sequence of the programme

ACTIVITY 5

Choose the best font from the box below for a title for each of these genres:

• Horror • Romantic comedy • Science fiction • Game show • Crime fiction

In each case the show is called *Last Chance*.

ALGERIAN	Fashion	MATISSE
Bauhaus	**Goudy heavyface**	**Matura Script Capitals**
Blackadder	Jokerman	Old English Text
Broadway	*Lucida Handwriting*	**Playbill**
Chiller	Rendo	**Serpentine**

If you prefer, find suitable fonts on a computer or design your own.

Case study: the title sequences to *Star Trek*



Star Trek was hugely popular in the 1960s

Sometimes the title sequence of a programme can become famous in its own right. In the 1960s the USA and Soviet Union were competing to put a man on the moon. *Star Trek* was first made in 1964 to exploit the interest in space travel this caused.

A voice-over was used in the title sequence to give the audience background information about the story. It explained that the crew of the star ship *Enterprise* were on a five-year mission to explore space – to 'seek out new life and new civilisations …' and 'boldly go where no man has gone before'. This phrase has become almost as famous as the series itself. Meanwhile the visual sequence showed the starship leaving the solar system and moving out into space.

Sequels used a similar title sequence, but changed 'no man' to 'no one'– what reason can you suggest for the change?

TIP

Writing about the historical events that influence the programme-makers shows the examiner that you understand its context.



10 Later series of *Star Trek* kept the 'voyage of discovery' theme

KEY TERMS

Prequel programme or series set in a time period before the first series, e.g. *Superman – the Early Years* or *Star Wars: Episode 1 The Phantom Menace*

Sequel continuation of a story, usually with the same characters or settings and themes

Star Trek – the prequel

There have been many more *Star Trek* sequels, but when the title sequence to the **prequel** *Enterprise* (2001) was being designed new ideas were needed to give the show a different feel.

Enterprise is set 150 years after the present and 105 years before the original series. The early version of the starship *Enterprise* travels mainly in the solar system and is technologically behind the original and its sequels.

The title sequence abandons the usual style and instead shows a historical summary of human achievement in travel and discovery and human aspiration to travel in space. The ships shown in the sequence are all called *Enterprise* but they are not all starships.

The fictitious starships include the first warp ship, the *Phoenix*, as seen in the feature film *Star Trek: First Contact* (1996), and finally, the 'new' *Enterprise NX-01* that features in the series. Try to watch the sequence. At what point does the title sequence change from historical accuracy to fictitious events based on the *Star Trek* stories?

TIP

You can find the lyrics of *Faith of the Heart* by following the links on Heinemann Hotlinks.

As well as changes to the overall visual style of the title sequence, *Enterprise* has a very different signature tune. Instead of the instrumental cue of the other series it has a contemporary soft-rock song called *Faith of the Heart*, performed by English opera tenor Russell Watson. The melody and the lyrics work alongside the pictures to suggest the past, present and future as well as the mission of Enterprise (both the series and the ship).

Media texts offer the audience a view of the world and sometimes invite them to make a judgement about events. How does the title sequence of *Enterprise* represent mankind's experience in terms of travel and discovery?

ACTIVITY 10

Look at the title sequences of the original *Star Trek* series, its sequels and prequels. How is human progress represented?

ACTIVITY 11 EXTENSION

1 Watch a variety of title sequences. Comment on how meaning is conveyed through visual images and soundtrack. Consider:
   - how location and time are established
   - how groups of people are represented, if at all
   - how the soundtrack gives clues about the content of the programme
   - how any lettering used relates to the rest of the sequence.

2 **Storyboard** a title sequence of your own to launch a new programme (see pages 172–173 in Unit 9 if you need help). Think about all the features you looked out for in the sequences you watched.

TIP

Put your storyboard from Activity 11 into a folder. This could be included in your final coursework folder as planning or pre-production work.

Television genres



In media terms, a genre is any type of text – programme, film, popular music, etc. – that can be identified or recognised by typical conventions or characteristics (see pages 13–14).

ACTIVITY 12

1 Look in the daily TV schedule in a newspaper. List all the genres that you can find, such as situation comedy and news.

2 In small groups, think of a new TV programme aimed at teenagers. Write down what genre the programme belongs to and when it will be shown. Add any other important details, such as what will happen and who will feature in it.

3 Present your ideas to the rest of the class, and hear the ideas of other groups.

4 Think about all the ideas put forward. What were the most noticeable similarities and differences? Were there any particularly popular genres of programmes? Why might that be?

You will probably notice that some television genres are more popular than others, and that these are often scheduled during peak time. TV programmes are produced by teams of people who conduct extensive **market research** in order to find out what different audiences want to see on television. They are aware that audiences use the media to satisfy certain needs or requirements. Blumler and Katz discussed such audience demand in 1974 in their theory of Uses and Gratifications (see page 88). In summary, they suggested that audiences need to:

- be INFORMED and EDUCATED about the world
- IDENTIFY with characters and situations
- be ENTERTAINED
- use the media as a talking point for SOCIAL INTERACTION
- ESCAPE from their daily lives.

KEY TERMS

Market research finding out what audiences like or dislike about aspects of the media through interviews, surveys and focus groups

Storyboard key moments of a story shown using images and notes – see the example on page 107

Sub-genre genres can be divided up further into sub-genres, e.g. teen comedies are a sub-genre of comedy

ACTIVITY 13

Look again at the television programmes and genres you identified in the daily schedules. Apply the Uses and Gratifications theory to them in order to see what audience needs are being satisfied by each genre. Put your answers in a table like the one below by writing ticks in the correct columns.

Programme	Inform	Identify	Entertain	Social interaction	Escape
Wildlife documentary	✓		✓	✓	

Introduction to television drama

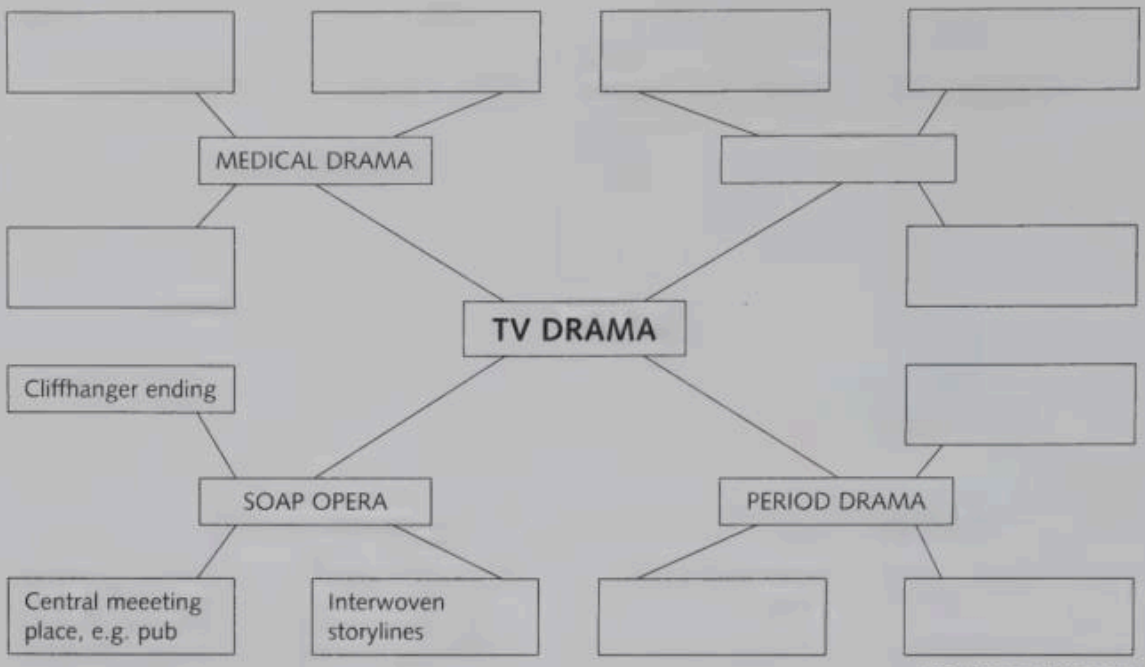
Television drama is a hugely popular television genre, attracting wide-ranging audiences simply because there are so many different dramas to choose from in terms of both style and content. Since it is such a large genre, it is useful to divide it up further into **sub-genres** such as medical drama, police drama and docu-drama, in order to look at it more closely



11 David Jason in the Yorkshire Television drama *Micawber* (2002)

ACTIVITY 14

1. Watch the opening sequences of a range of TV dramas. Finish a copy of diagram **12** showing the typical sub-genre conventions or characteristics of each one. One has been done for you already. You may need to add more arms or boxes.
2. What other impressions do you get from the opening sequences? Try to add in more notes on your diagram about any of the following areas: *music, striking images, on-screen text.*
3. Discuss with a partner what storylines are suggested by the openings. What clues tell you the kinds of stories that will be important in the programmes? Look out for where the camera spends extra time, giving importance to certain moments and particular characters and their stories.



12 Mapping TV genres

Camera work

Some types of camera shots are used a lot in TV drama. The aim is to make it seem as though the audience is either 'there' in the scene through point-of-view shots or 'looking on' through the use of lots of close-ups and shots through windows and doors (see **13**).



13 A close-up from *The Bill*

Characters

Having central characters that the audience can get to know in lots of detail is absolutely essential to TV drama. These may play certain roles in the story, for example heroes, villains and helpers (see page 101).